

A Tense Friendship

I could feel the tension in my gut as I took my seat in the RSI box, and I hated it. All rational thought said Danni was ready, and I wanted to feel that confidence. Instead, irrational thoughts of disaster flooded my brain, and all I felt was sick.

To my left - nearly a quarter of the way around the arena - I could see the owner of Cheryl's stable clustered with some members of his staff. If he saw me, he gave no acknowledgment. There was no particular animosity between us - which is a bit surprising, given how often our stables have come up against each other in big moments like this - but we weren't friendly, either. Truth is, we simply didn't know each other very well.

As for me, I was once again alone in the box. The only 'staff' I had were all hard at work.

I expected it would stay that way when there was a soft knock at the door.

I opened it to find the owner of *Dragon's Den* - who is simply known as Dragon - and his stable leader, Sophia Bush.

"Well," I said, "what has you two slumming in this part of the arena?"

"I was thrown out of my box," Dragon said curtly.

"I'm sorry... what?"

"Apparently, I had a drink too many. Perhaps more than that. Witnesses reported that I became belligerent, and I was eventually removed by security. I remember none of this, of course."

He was kidding. I was sure of it. Well, mostly sure of it. An incident like that is something I'm fairly certain I would have heard about. But I didn't say anything because, with Dragon, I can never be absolutely positive.

"Would you stop wasting time trying to be funny?" Sophia snapped playfully.

Dragon shrugged, then stepped aside and let his stable leader take over the conversation.

"How are you?" she asked me.

"Tense," I answered honestly. "And you?"

Sophia was much more than Danni's fellow stable leader. The two were friends, having worked together for years on the hit show *One Tree Hill*. It's a friendship that has sometimes given me agita, but it's also led to unprecedented cooperation between the stables that has worked to the benefit of all involved.

"The same," she answered, "but she's been rock solid recently, right?"

Another similarity between Danni and her friend is that they occupy the same weight class. In fact, the two had been contending for the same crown at this event. Sophia's bid was abruptly ended in round two by... you guessed it... Cheryl Cole.

Point is, thanks to RSI's cross-training agreement with the Den, Danni and Sophia often train and spar together. That put the Den leader in excellent position to know exactly how far Danni's game had come over these past months.

"I've never seen her better," I agreed.

Sophia smiled, then we all stood there looking at each other for a few moments.

"So, why are you here again?" I asked.

"We thought maybe you could use some company," Sophia said.

My true feelings showed on my face before I even had a chance to think about hiding them. The last thing I wanted right now was company. I was wound up so tight, it wasn't going to take much to cause me to lose my mind. My plan was to try and let it out in small increments throughout the fight, and I was thankful for the soundproof glass because some choice words were definitely going to be said. And if things really went wrong, I could retreat to the back of the box and throw shit where no one would see me.

In other words, I didn't need an audience for what was about to happen.

Sophia read my expression, and I could see she was disappointed. More disappointed than the situation warranted, to be honest. She had politely offered to keep me company, and I was about to politely decline. What was the big deal?

Oh... duh.

She wasn't just here for me. Like everybody else, she was worried about Danni.

I looked at her - her left eye still a little discolored from the thumping Cole had given her - and realized what she really wanted was a friend.

God damn Danni, I thought to myself. Makes everybody care about her, and then ties us all up in knots.

"Come on in," I said.

The two made their way in, with Dragon immediately noticing the small buffet table in the back was cold and empty.

"I wasn't expecting company," I explained, "and since I already feel like I'm going to throw up, I decided to skip the food. I think I've got some drinks back here, though."

"I'll take a water if you've got it," Sophia said.

I nodded then looked to Dragon, and I could practically see the words *Do you have a beer in there?* written on his face.

Then Sophia hit him with her elbow and he said, "Water would be fine."

I laughed as I fished three waters out of the fridge.

"Looks like you found someone to keep you on the straight and narrow," I said to Dragon.

He shrugged and said, "Someone probably should."

Need another similarity between Sophia and Danni? Well, it just so happens they're both dating their boss. While Danni and I were still unconfirmed, Dragon and Sophia were an official item.

Oddly, their relationship was viewed as somewhat scandalous, while it seemed the world was just itching to celebrate Danni and I.

Sounds to me like a gender parity issue. Or maybe a gay rights thing? A straight rights problem?

Regardless, I was sure there were lawyers somewhere praying that it all went to shit.

I tipped my bottle toward Dragon as we took our seats along the glass.

"Congrats on Josie's big win," I said.

"Thank you," he said. "Sorry it had to come at Jen's expense. She certainly made it interesting, though."

I shrugged.

"I'd have preferred a different result, but Josie deserved it. And Jen will be back, I think."

"Winning four titles isn't enough for you?" he asked. "You have to win them all?"

"Oh, I would never say something like that," I said.

Then I smiled broadly and added, "Doesn't mean I don't think it, though."

That drew a laugh from both of them as we settled in.

"Besides," I said as I turned my attention to the cage below, "it's going to be five titles soon."

My bravado was patently false, and Sophia saw right through it.

"Are you really worried?" she asked.

"I'm always worried," I said. "It's my natural state of being."

"I think she's got this."

"So do I," I said, "but that doesn't stop me from worrying."

Suddenly the announcer's voice filled the arena, and a little wave of panic washed over me.

It was time.